# Remote Controller with Fail-Safe Update

Concept of Operations

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|---|---|
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# 1.0 Introduction

## 1.1 Project Description

### 1.1.1 Background

**Purpose:** The System lets an operator on the ground command, monitor, and update a controller in space that nobody can reach, and keeps that controller working between contacts.

**Need:** A controller that nobody can reach must stay operable, observable, and correctable for its whole life. Operation, observability, and maintenance including in-flight modification over the specified lifetime are three areas a space software specification must cover [3, Annex B, items 5.11–5.13, p. 113].

**Worst-Case Failure:** A failed update can leave the controller unable to run any firmware and unable to accept new firmware. Without physical access, that state is permanent.

**Rationale:** The loss has happened. NASA records a mission terminated after an in-flight software upload omitted a patch for a defective countdown timer; its recommendations include test-bed verification of in-flight software updates [4, Lesson 0559, p. 199].

### 1.1.2 Assumptions and Constraints

**C-1** The ground cannot talk to the controller directly. Every command, report, and firmware image passes through the onboard computer.

**C-2** All software is built to NASA's software engineering requirements. Rigor per part is set by its software class [5, Sec. 3.5.1, p. 24; App. C].

**C-3** One engineer builds and checks the System. No independent team reviews the work.

**C-4** The System runs on commercial development boards, not on spacecraft hardware. It can show how the System behaves, not that it would survive launch or space.

**A-1** Once launched, physical access to the onboard computer or controller is impossible; all fixes and updates must arrive by radio.

**A-2** The controller can lose power at any moment, even halfway through writing new firmware. The System must survive that without losing the controller [2, App. A, Table 2, p. 63].

**A-3** The ground can reach the spacecraft only during line-of-sight contact windows **[TBD-5]**. Between contacts the System must work on its own.

**A-4** One person operates the ground station. No second person checks a command before it is sent, so the System itself must refuse wrong commands.

**A-5** Radiation in space can flip single bits in memory, so stored firmware can change on its own. The System must not run firmware that has changed [2, App. A, Table 2, p. 63].

***Note.*** *A constraint (C) is a limit the System must work within; it is imposed, not chosen. An assumption (A) is a condition taken as true without proof; the design depends on it, and if it proves false the design may be wrong.* ***[TBR-**n**]*** *marks a proposal the author has not yet accepted;* ***[TBD-**n**]*** *marks a value not yet known. Both are listed in App. C.*

## 1.2 Overview of the Envisioned System

### 1.2.1 Overview

The System comprises two spatially separated operational segments. The **ground segment** on Earth includes the operator, the mission operations center running ground software, and the ground station antenna [6, Sec. 11.2, p. 305]. The **space segment** in orbit consists of the onboard computer and the controller, which operate without physical access.

Communication between segments is strictly established via a radio link during line-of-sight contact windows [**TBD-5**]. Outside contact windows, the space segment operates autonomously. Within the spacecraft, the onboard computer communicates with the controller over the data link during normal operation. If the controller's main firmware fails to execute, the onboard computer utilizes the reprogramming link to restore functional firmware independently of the controller's primary software. Figure 1 illustrates this segment layout.

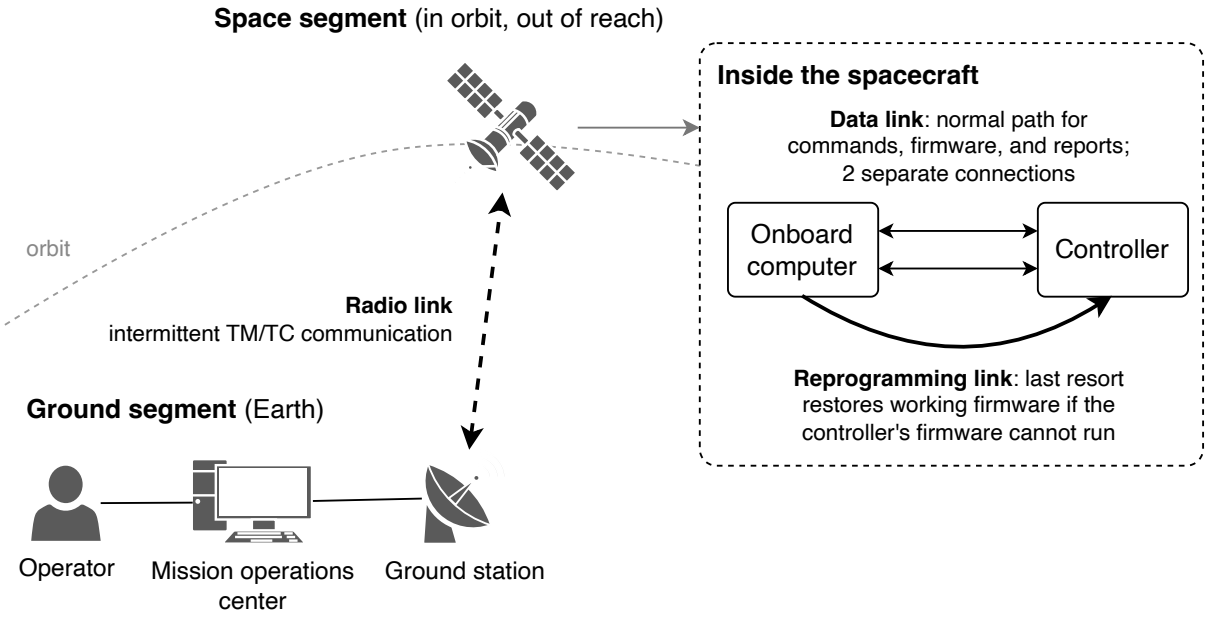



Figure 1: Ground and space segments, joined only by the radio link during contact windows. Inside the spacecraft, the data link handles normal communication, while the reprogramming link restores working firmware if the controller's firmware cannot run.

### 1.2.2 System Scope

The system context defines the boundary of the System: the system of interest, its users, and the external elements that interface with it [7, Sec. 8.3, p. 24].

| Context Element | System Boundary |
|---|---|
| System of Interest | Onboard computer, controller, ground software in the MOC |
| Users | Ground operator |
| External Elements | Radio equipment, spacecraft power supply |

- **Enabling systems:** firmware build tools and bench test setups required for development and verification, external to operational scope.
- **In scope:** commanding, telemetry, firmware updates, and autonomous fault handling between contact windows [**TBR-5**].
- **Out of scope:** onboard computer software updates [**TBR-7**], and the radio equipment, which is used as given.

# 2.0 Documents

## 2.1 Applicable Documents

[1] NASA, *NASA Systems Engineering Handbook*, NASA/SP-2016-6105 Rev 2, 2016. This outline follows its App. S, pp. 251–253, tailored per its Sec. 3.11.1, p. 34: Section 7.0 not applicable; App. C added for open items per its App. C, pp. 197–198.

## 2.2 Reference Documents

[2] NASA, *Software Assurance and Software Safety Standard*, NASA-STD-8739.8B, 2022. Off-nominal scenarios cite App. A, Table 2.
[3] ESA, *Space engineering — Software*, ECSS-E-ST-40C Rev. 1, 30 April 2025.
[4] NASA, *Fault Management Handbook*, NASA-HDBK-1002, Draft 2, 2 April 2012. A draft, not a released standard.
[5] NASA, *NASA Software Engineering Requirements*, NPR 7150.2D.
[6] NASA, *State-of-the-Art of Small Spacecraft Technology*, Chapter 11, "Ground Data Systems and Mission Operations", 2026 edition. Ground system architecture in Sec. 11.2 and Fig. 11.2, pp. 305–306.
[7] NASA, *NASA Systems Modeling Handbook for Systems Engineering*, NASA-HDBK-1009A, 12 March 2025.

# 3.0 Description of Envisioned System

## 3.1 Needs, Goals and Objectives

**NEED** A controller that nobody can reach must stay operable, observable and correctable for its whole life.

**G-1** **Operability:** the controller keeps running and acts on the operator's commands.
- **O-1** Every valid operator command is executed. Valid means from the operator, allowed in the current state, with possible values, and not expired.
- **O-2** Firmware and commands not from the operator are never acted on.
- **O-3** With one data-link connection lost, commands, telemetry and updates continue.
- **O-4** No fault found between contacts goes unreported [**TBR-5**].

**G-2** **Observability:** the ground can know what the System is doing, how healthy it is, and what happened between contacts.
- **O-5** No report is lost without the ground being told.

**G-3** **Correctability:** the controller's firmware can be replaced for its whole life without losing the controller.
- **O-6** No update, even one interrupted by a single fault, leaves the controller without runnable firmware.

## 3.2 Overview of System and Key Elements

**Operator** The user. Decides and sends commands, releases new firmware, and reads the reports.

**Ground software** In the mission operations center. Turns the operator's decisions into commands and firmware ready to send, checks them before they leave, and keeps every report received.

**Onboard computer** Checks commands and firmware and passes them to the controller, stores the controller's reports between contacts, watches the controller, and restores it when its firmware cannot run.

**Controller** Runs its firmware, acts on commands, reports its state, and returns to working firmware on its own when new firmware fails.

The ground station's radio equipment and the spacecraft power supply are outside the System; it uses them as given.

## 3.3 Interfaces

**External interfaces**

**Operator interface** Human. Ground software to operator. Allows the flight operator to issue telecommands, authorize firmware deployments, and monitor system telemetry.

**Radio link** Radio frequency. Ground software to onboard computer via external radio equipment. Provides intermittent telemetry and telecommand (TM/TC) transfer exclusively during contact windows.

**Power** Electrical. Spacecraft power subsystem to onboard computer and controller. Subject to unannounced power interruptions at any time (assumption A-2).

**Interfaces between elements**

**Data link** Digital data. Onboard computer to controller. Nominal interface for commands, telemetry, and firmware updates while controller firmware is running. Uses two separate connections, so a single connection failure does not interrupt operations.

**Reprogramming link** Digital data. Onboard computer to controller. Recovery interface used as a last resort to restore functional firmware independently of the controller's main software.

## 3.4 Modes of Operations

**Life-cycle modes of the System**

**Test** Ground bench execution with simulated radio link degradation and intentional fault injection to demonstrate operational scenarios.

**Operation** Active mission execution using the controller modes detailed below.

**Disposal** Not applicable; limited to bench demonstration scope.

**Controller modes during operation**

**OPERATE** Nominal state executing confirmed firmware. New firmware images can be staged in the background during execution [**TBR-6**].

**TRIAL** Entered upon transitioning to updated firmware. Executes the new image for a bounded evaluation window [**TBD-6**]. If the new image is judged good, the update is committed and the controller returns to OPERATE; if not, it enters FALLBACK.

**FALLBACK** Entered following a failed firmware trial or boot failure. Reverts execution to the previous known-good firmware image or the last-resort firmware.

**RECOVERY** Entered when no operational firmware image can be executed. Controller software execution is halted while the onboard computer restores functional firmware via the reprogramming link.

## 3.5 Proposed Capabilities

**Telemetry** (serves G-2 Observability)

**Capability-1** Generate periodic health reports detailing operational status, active firmware version, uptime, reset cause, and thermal telemetry.

**Capability-2** Generate asynchronous event-driven reports immediately upon significant state changes or operational events.
**Capability-3** Apply time tags to all generated telemetry reports.
**Capability-4** Store telemetry reports during out-of-contact periods for downlink during subsequent contact windows, including notification of any unrecoverable telemetry data loss.
**Capability-5** Monitor and report health status for each connection of the data link.

**Command handling** (serves G-1 Operability)
**Capability-6** Execute telecommands originating exclusively from the authorized ground operator and reject replay attacks.
**Capability-7** Acknowledge command reception, disposition (executed or rejected with cause), and completion status for every incoming telecommand.
**Capability-8** Reject telecommands invalid for the current operational mode.
**Capability-9** Run a repeated telecommand only once.
**Capability-10** Enforce a two-step "arm and execute" protocol for critical operations.
**Capability-11** Reject telecommands containing out-of-bounds parameter values.
**Capability-12** Allow the operator to abort an in-progress firmware update while preserving current operational firmware.
**Capability-13** Support time-tagged command execution and reject expired commands.
**Capability-14** Maintain a command log recording all incoming telecommands and execution responses.

**Fault handling** (serves G-1 Operability) [**TBR-5**]
**Capability-15** Detect controller unresponsiveness and initiate autonomous recovery sequences.
**Capability-16** Automatically fail over to the redundant data-link connection upon single-path failure.
**Capability-17** Restart crashed onboard processes and continue where they stopped.
**Capability-18** Log all detected fault events and executed recovery actions for subsequent downlink.

**Update** (serves G-3 Correctability)
**Capability-19** Support reliable firmware image reception across intermittent radio contact windows.
**Capability-20** Validate firmware integrity, source authentication, target compatibility, and version policy (preventing unauthorized rollbacks).
**Capability-21** Transfer validated firmware images to the controller.
**Capability-22** Transition execution to newly uploaded firmware, with the activation trigger and scheduling criteria [**TBD-3**].
**Capability-23** Evaluate new firmware operational validity post-boot; who judges is open [**TBD-4**].
**Capability-24** Automatically roll back to operational firmware if trial evaluation fails, without ground intervention.
**Capability-25** Downlink firmware update outcome reports to the ground segment.

**Test** (verification only)
**Capability-26** Provide controlled, deliberate radio link degradation during bench testing.
**Capability-27** Support command-driven injection of power interrupts and data-link disconnection faults [**TBR-10**].

**Disposal:** none; operational scope limited to bench demonstration.

# 4.0 Physical Environment

This section gives the environment the System must work in across its life cycle: operation in the mission it imitates, and integration and test on the laboratory bench. For each condition it states whether the System must operate, tolerate the condition with degraded performance, or only survive it [1, App. S, p. 252].

| Phase | Condition | Response | Scenario |
|---|---|---|---|
| Operation | Temperature range | **[TBD-9]** | — |
| Operation | Vacuum | NOT DEMONSTRATED | — |
| Operation | Radiation: single-bit memory errors | OPERATE | Scenario-400 |
| Operation | Electrical: power interruptions at any instant | SURVIVE | Scenario-340 |
| Launch | Vibration and launch loads | NOT DEMONSTRATED | — |
| Integration and test | Laboratory bench: room temperature and pressure | OPERATE | All |

Legend: OPERATE = all functions continue; TOLERATE = some functions are degraded, none is lost for good; SURVIVE = functions stop and return when the condition ends; NOT DEMONSTRATED = beyond what bench hardware can show (constraint C-4). Transportation: not applicable; the System is not transported.

# 5.0 Support Environment

Firmware is built and released on the ground and sent up during contacts, one transfer across several if needed. The onboard computer keeps the last known-good firmware. Update rate **[TBD-8]**. Nothing is repaired after deployment.

# 6.0 Operational Scenarios

Every scenario below is demonstrated on hardware and recorded.

## 6.1 Nominal Conditions

**Scenario-100** Update: release, upload over one or more contacts, check, transfer **[TBR-6]**, switch **[TBD-3]**, judged good **[TBD-4]**, confirmed, outcome reported.

**Scenario-110** Telemetry: reports stamped and stored between contacts, all sent at the next one.

**Scenario-120** Scheduled command: received during a contact, runs at its time, answer sent at the next contact.

## 6.2 Off-Nominal Conditions

Trigger, then expected outcome. Sources in brackets are items of [2, App. A, Table 2].

**Scenario-200** Ground link lost mid-transfer: resumes next contact where it stopped.

**Scenario-210** Command not from operator or replayed: refused, logged [2, p. 62].

**Scenario-220** Answer lost, command resent: not run again, “already done”.

**Scenario-230** Command wrong for current state: refused with reason [2, p. 63].

**Scenario-240** Impossible value: refused with reason [2, p. 62].

**Scenario-250** Dangerous command not armed: refused with reason.

**Scenario-260** Command expired: refused with reason [2, p. 63].
**Scenario-270** Report storage full: ground told how many were lost.
**Scenario-300** Firmware damaged in transfer: refused before the controller [2, p. 63].
**Scenario-310** Firmware not from operator: refused.
**Scenario-320** Firmware below minimum version: refused.
**Scenario-330** Firmware for another controller: refused [2, p. 63].
**Scenario-340** Power lost during firmware write: previous firmware runs; retry possible [2, p. 63].
**Scenario-350** New firmware hangs: back to previous, unaided.
**Scenario-360** New firmware restart loop: back to previous after **[TBD-7]** starts [2, p. 64].
**Scenario-370** New firmware never judged good: back to previous.
**Scenario-380** Previous firmware also bad: last-resort firmware runs.
**Scenario-390** Operator cancels update: known-good firmware left running.
**Scenario-400** Bit error in stored firmware: detected, not run **[TBR-9]** [2, p. 63].
**Scenario-410** No firmware can run: restored through the reprogramming link [2, p. 63].
**Scenario-500** One data-link connection fails: everything continues on the other; reported.
**Scenario-510** Both data-link connections fail: controller keeps working; loss reported; reprogramming link still usable **[TBR-8]**.
**Scenario-520** Controller silent: noticed, recovery tried, recorded **[TBR-5]**.
**Scenario-530** Onboard program crash: it restarts and resumes any update; the controller is unaffected **[TBR-5]**.

## 7.0 Impact Considerations

Not applicable: bench demonstration.

## 8.0 Risks and Potential Issues

**R-1** Both data-link connections may share software; one defect could cut both.
**R-2** Controller memory may not hold last-resort plus two working firmwares.
**R-3** Second data-link connection and reprogramming link not yet shown on bench.
**R-4** Demonstration date **[TBD-2]**; undemonstrated scenarios are declared, not dropped.

## A Acronyms

**ConOps** Concept of Operations
**MOC** Mission operations center
**TBD** To Be Determined
**TBR** To Be Resolved
**TC** Telecommand
**TM** Telemetry

## B Glossary

**Confirmed** Firmware judged good after its trial; only confirmed firmware is known-good.
**Last-resort** Known-good firmware that updates never replace (golden image).
**Switch** The controller stops running old firmware and starts the new.
**Arm** First step of a dangerous command; changes nothing alone.
**Expiry** Time after which a waiting command is refused.

# C Open Items

Unmarked statements were stated or accepted by the author on 9–10 October 2026. TBR items are resolved before the hazard analysis.

### Resolved

**TBR-1** Spacecraft controller, ground contacts only, no physical access, bench stand-in, bit errors occur, no repair. Accepted by the author, 10 October 2026.

**TBR-2** Controller power can drop at any instant, including mid-write. Accepted by the author, 10 October 2026.

**TBR-3** One operator. Accepted by the author, 10 October 2026.

**TBR-4** Capability-1, Capability-2, Capability-3 and Capability-5 as written. Accepted by the author, 10 October 2026.

### Open

**TBR-5** O-4 and Capability-15 to Capability-18 as written (shown 10 Oct, not yet accepted).

**TBR-6** Controller keeps working while new firmware arrives.

**TBR-7** Onboard computer's own update out of scope.

**TBR-8** Reprogramming link still usable with both data-link connections lost.

**TBR-9** Stored firmware checked before start; damaged copy skipped.

**TBR-10** Test setup can cut power and break one connection.

**TBD-1** Project name and document reference.

**TBD-2** Demonstration date.

**TBD-3** Switch automatically on arrival, or only on operator command.

**TBD-4** Who judges new firmware good: controller or operator.

**TBD-5** Contact window length and gap (sourced, or a test parameter).

**TBD-6** Trial time limit (requirements).

**TBD-7** Failed starts before going back (requirements).

**TBD-8** Update rate.

**TBD-9** Temperature range.